

PART 19: LEARNING RESOURCES & PRACTICE SYSTEM

The PM body of knowledge is sprawling. This chapter is your compass — the curated resources, the practice routines, and the systems for continuous improvement.

The goal isn't to consume everything. It's to know what's worth your time and to build durable habits.

19.1 The Curated Book List

Books retain value better than blog posts. The best PM books still teach you something 5-10 years after publication.

Tier 1 — Must Read in Year 1

These are the books every PM should read in their first year.

Book	Author	What it teaches
<i>Inspired</i>	Marty Cagan	Foundations of modern PM
<i>The Mom Test</i>	Rob Fitzpatrick	Customer discovery
<i>Continuous Discovery Habits</i>	Teresa Torres	Ongoing user research
<i>Cracking the PM Career</i>	Bavaro & McDowell	The career path
<i>Hooked</i>	Nir Eyal	Habit-forming products
<i>The Lean Startup</i>	Eric Ries	Hypothesis-driven development
<i>Sprint</i>	Jake Knapp	The 5-day sprint method

Tier 2 — Year 2 Deepening

Once foundations are solid:

Book	Author	What it teaches
<i>Empowered</i>	Cagan & Jones	Product leadership
<i>Good Strategy / Bad Strategy</i>	Richard Rumelt	What strategy actually is
<i>Obviously Awesome</i>	April Dunford	Positioning
<i>7 Powers</i>	Hamilton Helmer	Competitive advantage

Book	Author	What it teaches
<i>The Lean Product Playbook</i>	Dan Olsen	Practical PMF
<i>Crossing the Chasm</i>	Geoffrey Moore	Early-to-mainstream transition
<i>Lean Analytics</i>	Croll & Yoskovitz	Metrics for product
<i>Trustworthy Online Controlled Experiments</i>	Kohavi et al.	A/B testing rigor
<i>User Story Mapping</i>	Jeff Patton	The craft of stories
<i>Don't Make Me Think</i>	Steve Krug	UX foundations
<i>The Design of Everyday Things</i>	Don Norman	Design thinking

Tier 3 — Strategic / Advanced

For senior PMs and aspiring leaders:

Book	Author	What it teaches
<i>Playing to Win</i>	Lafley & Martin	Strategic choice cascades
<i>The Cold Start Problem</i>	Andrew Chen	Network effects products
<i>The Innovator's Dilemma</i>	Clayton Christensen	Disruption theory
<i>Competing Against Luck</i>	Christensen	JTBD theory original
<i>Hacking Growth</i>	Sean Ellis	Growth methodology
<i>Product-Led Growth</i>	Wes Bush	PLG playbook
<i>Monetizing Innovation</i>	Madhavan Ramanujam	Pricing-led product
<i>Predictable Revenue</i>	Aaron Ross	Outbound sales for SaaS
<i>Measure What Matters</i>	John Doerr	OKRs
<i>High Output Management</i>	Andy Grove	Foundational management
<i>Crucial Conversations</i>	Patterson et al.	High-stakes communication
<i>Difficult Conversations</i>	Stone et al.	Harvard NP communication
<i>Never Split the Difference</i>	Chris Voss	Negotiation
<i>The Pyramid Principle</i>	Barbara Minto	Structured business writing
<i>Designing Data-Intensive Applications</i>	Martin Kleppmann	Technical depth

Tier 4 — Specialized / Domain-Specific

Read based on your domain:

For AI Products:

- *AI Engineering* — Chip Huyen

- *Designing Machine Learning Systems* — Chip Huyen
- *The Alignment Problem* — Brian Christian

For B2B / Enterprise:

- *The Sales Acceleration Formula* — Mark Roberge
- *From Impossible to Inevitable* — Aaron Ross
- *Sales Enablement* — Cory Bray

For Marketplaces:

- *Modern Monopolies* — Moazed & Johnson
- *Platform Revolution* — Parker et al.

For Growth:

- Reforge programs (online courses, paid)
- *Growth Hacker Marketing* — Ryan Holiday

For Startups / 0→1:

- *Zero to One* — Peter Thiel
- *Disciplined Entrepreneurship* — Bill Aulet
- *The Startup Owner's Manual* — Steve Blank
- *The Hard Thing About Hard Things* — Ben Horowitz

For Indian Context:

- *The Made in India Manager* — R. Gopalakrishnan
- Various Indian unicorn founder memoirs (Zerodha, Flipkart, Razorpay)

Tier 5 — Adjacent / Mind-Expanding

Books that aren't strictly PM but shape how PMs think:

- *Thinking, Fast and Slow* — Daniel Kahneman
- *The Black Swan* — Nassim Taleb
- *Antifragile* — Nassim Taleb
- *Super Thinking* — Gabriel Weinberg
- *Thinking in Bets* — Annie Duke
- *The Almanack of Naval Ravikant* — Eric Jorgenson
- *Poor Charlie's Almanack* — Charlie Munger
- *Skin in the Game* — Nassim Taleb
- *Algorithms to Live By* — Brian Christian
- *Range* — David Epstein
- *Atomic Habits* — James Clear

- *Deep Work* — Cal Newport
- *Range* — David Epstein

Reading Cadence

Realistic targets:

- Year 1: 10-15 books (foundations).
- Year 2: 8-12 (deepening).
- Year 3+: 6-8 (specialized + adjacent).

Quality > quantity. Re-read the great ones.

19.2 Online Courses

Free or Freemium

Reforge Free Articles (reforge.com/blog) The blog is free; full programs are paid. The blog alone is worth weekly reading.

Lenny's Newsletter (lennysnewsletter.com) Free posts and archives are extensive. Full subscription unlocks more.

Y Combinator's Startup School (startupschool.org) Free; covers founding-PM skills. Strong videos.

Coursera — Product Management courses Multiple free or low-cost. Certificate optional.

- "Digital Product Management" — University of Virginia.
- "Product Management Specialization" — University of Maryland.

edX Various free courses. Search "Product Management."

Khan Academy Statistics and probability foundations (relevant for A/B testing literacy).

SVPG free articles (svpg.com) Marty Cagan's content. Foundational.

Paid (High Quality)

Reforge (reforge.com) Best paid PM education. Programs on growth, retention, monetization, AI products. ~\$2,000-3,000 per program; alumni access continues.

Product School (productschool.com) Comprehensive certification programs. Variable quality; generally good for beginners.

On Deck (beondeck.com) Cohort-based programs. Strong network.

Maven (maven.com) Marketplace of cohort-based courses by experienced operators. Growing rapidly. Many PM-specific.

Exponent (tryexponent.com) Best for interview prep. Mock interviews, courses, community.

Pragmatic Institute (pragmaticinstitute.com) Established PM training. More traditional.

Indian-Specific

Indian Product Management institutes:

- Sebastian's PM Bootcamp.
- ProductFolks community programs.
- ISB / IIM PM-focused executive programs.

Communities:

- ProductGeeks (India).
- Indian PM WhatsApp / Slack groups.
- Headout PM Network.
- Growth Hackers India.

Specific Skills

SQL:

- Mode SQL Tutorial (free).
- SQLBolt (free).
- DataLemur (free + paid).
- Khan Academy SQL.

Python / Pandas:

- Kaggle Pandas course (free).
- DataCamp.
- Real Python tutorials.

Statistics for PMs:

- Khan Academy.
- "Practical Statistics for Data Scientists" (book).
- Udacity A/B Testing course (free, by Google).

System Design:

- ByteByteGo (bytebytego.com).
- "System Design Interview" books by Alex Xu.
- High Scalability blog.

AI Products:

- DeepLearning.AI short courses (free).
- Hugging Face NLP course (free).

- Anthropic / OpenAI cookbooks (free).

UX / Design:

- Nielsen Norman Group articles (free).
- Laws of UX (lawsofux.com).

19.3 Top Blogs and Newsletters

Subscribe selectively. More is not better.

Tier 1 — Subscribe Today

- **Lenny's Newsletter** (lennysnewsletter.com) — Most comprehensive PM newsletter today.
- **Stratechery** (stratechery.com) — Ben Thompson; the gold standard for tech strategy. (Paid.)
- **Reforge Blog** (reforge.com/blog) — Practitioner-quality essays.
- **Shreyas Doshi** (Twitter @shreyas, Substack). Sharp, opinionated.
- **First Round Review** (review.firstround.com) — Long-form interviews with operators.
- **Marty Cagan / SVPG** (svpg.com/articles) — Foundational PM content.
- **Andrew Chen** (andrewchen.com) — Growth and network effects.

Tier 2 — Worthwhile

- **Brian Balfour** — Growth.
- **John Cutler** — TBM newsletter, product operations.
- **Julie Zhuo's The Looking Glass** — Leadership.
- **Will Larson's lethain.com** — Engineering leadership and PM-eng dynamics.
- **Tomasz Tunguz** — SaaS metrics.
- **Pragmatic Engineer** — Tech and PM-eng.
- **Aakash Gupta** — PM career content.
- **Casey Newton's Platformer** — Tech industry analysis.
- **Ben Evans** — Tech/strategy weekly.

Indian Tech / Strategy

- **The Ken** (the-ken.com) — Paid, sharp Indian tech analysis.
- **The Morning Context** — Indian business journalism.
- **Pragmatic Capitalist** — Indian entrepreneurship.
- **Filter Coffee** — Indian tech newsletter.
- **Kunal Shah's writings** (Cred founder; periodic essays).

Specialized

Strategy:

- Ben Thompson's *Stratechery* (above).
- *Acquired* podcast deep-dives.
- *Not Boring* by Packy McCormick — Strategy stories.

Growth:

- Brian Balfour's *Reforge* essays.
- Andrew Chen.
- Eric Bahn's *Hustle Fund* writing.

AI:

- Simon Willison's blog.
- Ben Thompson's AI coverage.
- Latent Space podcast (technical).
- Eugene Yan's ML blog.

India fintech:

- The Ken's fintech section.
- Razorpay's blog.
- Kunal Shah.

Newsletter Discipline

Subscribe to too few rather than too many. Read what you subscribe to. Cull regularly.

Default rhythm:

- Daily: 1-2 quick reads (5-10 min).
- Weekly: 2-3 deep reads (30-60 min total).
- Monthly: 1-2 long-form deep dives.

19.4 Podcasts

Audio is great for commutes and walks.

PM-Specific

Lenny's Podcast (lennypod.com) Best PM-focused podcast. Long interviews with senior PMs.

Masters of Scale (Reid Hoffman) Founders of major companies on building.

The Product Podcast (Product School) Variable quality; some great episodes.

Below the Line (Jason Lemkin) SaaS-focused. Great for B2B PMs.

Strategy / Business

Acquired (acquired.fm) 3-4 hour deep-dives on company histories. Best business podcast period. Free.

Stratechery Daily Update (Ben Thompson) Paid; brief daily strategic analysis.

Invest Like the Best (Patrick O'Shaughnessy) Long interviews; many strategic.

Founders Podcast (David Senra) Biographies of founders read and discussed. Highly recommended.

The Knowledge Project (Shane Parrish) Long-form on decision-making, mental models.

Tech / AI

Latent Space (swyx & Alessio) Best AI engineering podcast.

The Pragmatic Engineer Podcast Tech industry insights.

a16z Podcast Various tech/strategy episodes.

Indian-Specific

The Knowledge Project India (Naval Ravikant + others) Various interviews with Indian operators.

Paisha Vaisha by Anupam Gupta Indian fintech and personal finance.

Maed in India podcasts.

Founder Thesis by The Podium (Indian founder interviews).

Personal Development

The Tim Ferriss Show Long interviews; productive habits.

On Purpose with Jay Shetty Mindfulness and meaning.

Hidden Brain Behavioral science.

Listening Discipline

- Default speed 1.25-1.5x for most podcasts.
- 1.0x for dense (Acquired, Stratechery).
- Take notes on important insights.
- Don't listen if you're not absorbing. Quality > quantity.

19.5 Communities

Communities accelerate learning enormously. Join 2-3, not 20.

Global PM Communities

Lenny's Slack (paid Lenny's subscription) Highest quality PM community today. Active.

Mind the Product (mindtheproduct.com) Free + paid tiers. Conferences globally.

Product School Slack and Meetups Beginner-friendly. Free.

ProductCraft (productcraft.com) Pendo-sponsored community.

Reforge Alumni Network Strong; requires Reforge program.

Indian PM Communities

ProductFolks (Indian PM community) Very active; great for warm intros.

ProductGeeks Indian-specific PM community.

Indian PM WhatsApp groups (numerous; ask around).

LinkedIn Indian PM groups.

IIT / IIM alumni networks (often have PM-focused subgroups).

Specialized

Growth-focused:

- GrowthHackers (growthhackers.com).
- Reforge alumni (paid).

AI Product:

- AI Engineer Summit community.
- Latent Space community.

Marketplaces:

- Local marketplace founder groups.

B2B SaaS:

- SaaSStock community.
- OpenView Partners network.

Engagement Patterns

Effective community participation:

- Share something useful weekly (a learning, a question, a help).

- Help others' problems generously.
- Ask focused questions; don't dump.
- Build 5-10 substantive relationships, not 500 superficial ones.
- Show up to in-person events when possible.

Communities reward generosity. Take less than you give.

19.6 Daily Practice Habits

The compound interest of small daily habits over years is staggering.

The 10-Minute Daily Drill

Pick one. Do it daily.

Option A: Product teardown sentence. Pick a product or feature you encountered today. Write 1-2 sentences on: who is this for, what JTBD does it serve, what's surprising about how it's designed.

Option B: Strategic news commentary. Read 1 tech news item. Write 2-3 sentences: what's the strategic move, what trade-off was made, who wins, who loses.

Option C: Metric reflection. Pick a metric (any metric). Write 1-2 sentences: what does it measure, what would make it move, what's its weakness.

Option D: User pain log. Note 1 user pain you experienced today (your own, or observed). What's the underlying job? What's the workaround?

10 minutes daily for a year = 60 hours of deliberate PM thinking.

The 30-Minute Weekly Drill

Once a week, longer practice. Pick one.

Option A: Full product teardown. Pick a product. Use the Part 12 template. Write a 2-page teardown.

Option B: Strategy memo. Pick a public company. Write a 2-page strategic memo on what they should do next. Use the Part 4 framework.

Option C: PRD practice. Pick a hypothetical feature. Write a complete PRD using the Part 6 template. ~1500 words.

Option D: Mock interview. Solo with recording, or with a friend, or via AI. 45-min full mock. Self-evaluate.

Option E: SQL / data analysis exercise. Solve a problem on DataLemur or StrataScratch. Or analyze a dataset on Kaggle.

30 minutes weekly = 26 hours of deliberate practice annually.

The 1-Hour Monthly Practice

Once a month, do something more substantial.

Option A: Public writing. Publish a 1000-word post on LinkedIn or Substack. Could be: a teardown, an insight, a learned lesson. Build your portfolio publicly.

Option B: Conduct user interviews. 3-5 customer/prospect interviews on a topic you're researching. Synthesize into a memo.

Option C: Build something small. A no-code app, a Notion template, a useful internal tool. 0→1 muscle.

Option D: Deep dive on a topic. Spend an hour learning a new framework, tool, or domain. Write up what you learned.

The Quarterly Review

Once a quarter, review yourself:

- What outcomes did I drive last quarter?
- What did I learn?
- What anti-pattern did I fall into?
- What should I do differently next quarter?
- What's one big thing I'll commit to?

Write it down. Re-read in 90 days.

19.7 Building a Public Portfolio

Public writing is the single most underrated PM career accelerator.

Why It Works

- Forces clarity (writing reveals weak thinking).
- Compounds reputation over time.
- Attracts opportunities you didn't ask for.
- Builds your network organically.
- Demonstrates skill better than a resume.

What to Publish

- **Product teardowns.** Use the Part 12 template.
- **Strategic analysis.** Public companies, recent news.
- **Frameworks and lessons.** Things you've learned and synthesized.
- **Career stories.** Your own learnings (when appropriate).
- **Industry observations.** Patterns you see.

Where to Publish

- **LinkedIn:** Best for PM-career visibility. Most PMs find new roles through here.
- **Substack / Medium / personal blog:** For longer-form, more thoughtful writing.
- **Twitter/X:** Short-form, quick observations, networking.
- **Industry-specific:** Hashnode, Dev.to (for developer-focused content), etc.

Cadence

- Start: 1 post per month.
- Build to: 1 post per 1-2 weeks.
- Don't sprint; build a sustainable habit.

What Stops Most People

- Imposter syndrome ("who am I to teach?").
- Perfection ("not ready yet").
- Fear of being wrong.

Reality:

- You don't have to teach. You can share what you're learning.
- Imperfect published is better than perfect unpublished.
- Most people are kind. The few who aren't are blocking-worthy.

After 12 months of consistent public writing, you'll have built more career capital than 5 years of resume-only work.

Examples to Model

Public PM writers worth studying:

- Lenny Rachitsky (Lenny's Newsletter)
- Shreyas Doshi
- John Cutler
- Aakash Gupta
- Many active PMs on LinkedIn

Read their early posts. They didn't start polished.

19.8 Tools to Install Today

If you're early in your PM career, set these up:

Writing & Knowledge

- **Notion or Roam** for knowledge management. Build your second brain.
- **Readwise** to capture highlights from books, articles. Resurfaces them periodically.

Productivity

- **Calendar discipline.** Block focus time.
- **Todoist or similar** for tasks.
- **Slack** (you'll have it for work).

Analytics

- **Sign up for free Amplitude or Mixpanel accounts** to learn the tools.
- **Mode Analytics** for SQL practice.

AI Tools

- **ChatGPT Plus or Claude Pro:** Daily PM assistant.
- **Perplexity Pro:** For research.
- **Cursor or VSCode + Copilot:** If you ever want to code.
- **Loom:** For async video communication.

Research & Discovery

- **Otter.ai or Fireflies:** Interview transcription.
- **Calendly:** Easy scheduling.
- **Tally or Typeform:** Surveys.

Design Tools (for fluency, not creation)

- **Figma:** Free tier; learn to navigate (don't have to design).

Newsletter Reader

- **Reeder, Feedly, or just email folders.** Centralize your subscriptions.

19.9 Free Hands-On Projects to Do This Week

If you're between jobs, pre-PM, or building toward APM applications, these projects build skills tangibly:

Project 1: Public Teardown

Pick a product you use. Write a 2,500-word teardown. Post on LinkedIn. Include 3 specific improvements you'd make as PM.

Project 2: Strategy Memo

Pick a public company you're interested in. Write a 1,500-word strategy memo: where they are, what's coming, what they should do.

Project 3: PRD for a Real Problem

Identify a real problem you've observed. Write a full PRD as if you were going to build the solution. Actually try to build the MVP with no-code tools.

Project 4: User Research Practice

Interview 5 friends about a specific problem (their workflows, pains, alternatives). Synthesize into a JTBD map and journey map.

Project 5: SQL Analysis

On a public dataset (Kaggle), answer 3 product-style questions: cohort retention, conversion funnel, segment differences.

Project 6: A/B Test Design

Design a complete A/B test for a product change you'd make. Hypothesis, metrics, sample size, analysis plan.

Project 7: Side Project Build

Use no-code tools to build a small functional product. Get 5 users. Iterate.

Project 8: PM Interview Prep Bank

Build your own STAR story bank with 10 stories. Use as a personal asset for years.

19.10 The PM Knowledge Stack — What to Master and When

A pacing guide:

Year 1: Foundations

- Inspired + Mom Test + Continuous Discovery Habits.
- Basic SQL.
- Understanding of: PM role, customer discovery, basic frameworks.
- Goal: Functional in any PM role.

Year 2: Depth

- Strategy books (Rumelt, Helmer).

- Lean Analytics, A/B testing, advanced metrics.
- Communication skills (Crucial Conversations, Pyramid Principle).
- Domain-specific knowledge.
- Goal: Can lead an area independently.

Year 3: Breadth

- Adjacent fields (technical, design, business).
- Strategic books, mental models.
- Public writing habit.
- Goal: Senior-level operator.

Year 4-5: Mastery

- Specialized expertise (your domain).
- Mentoring others.
- Ecosystem knowledge.
- Goal: Recognized expert.

Year 5+: Leadership

- Management (if going manager track).
- Strategic vision.
- Industry presence.
- Goal: Setting direction for teams or companies.

19.11 Avoiding Resource Overload

Here's the key insight: **information consumption is not learning**. Many PMs read voraciously without applying. The result is intellectualized confusion.

Better:

- **Read less; apply more.**
- **For each book, identify 3 things you'll do differently. Do them.**
- **Re-read great books.** They get better.
- **Skip the second-rate.** Life is short.

The best PMs are not the ones who've read the most. They're the ones who've extracted and applied the most.

19.12 References for Part 19

Cross-referenced; this part is itself a reference. The categories above contain hundreds of resources. Pick your starting points; expand over time.

End of Part 19. The final part is the comprehensive 12-month roadmap and APM readiness checklist. -e

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